ERA 7

An Age of Reform

1800 – 1848

The Second Great Awakening · abolition · women's rights · American culture

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did religious revival and reform movements seek to perfect American society?

KEY TERMS

Second Great Awakening · temperance · abolitionism · Seneca Falls · Transcendentalism

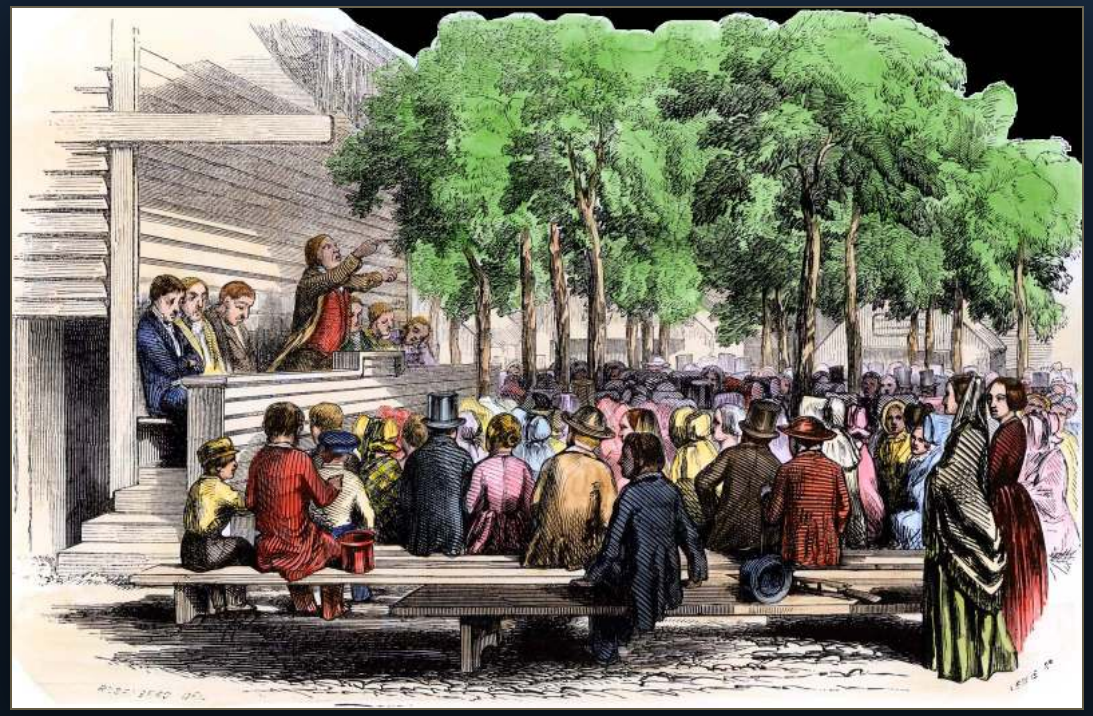
ALIGNED TO

CED Topics 4.9–4.11 · AMSCO Ch. 4.9–4.11

PERFECTING SOCIETY

An Age of Reform

The Second Great Awakening



- A wave of religious **revivals** swept the nation after 1800.
- Preachers like **Charles Finney** stressed personal salvation and free will.
- Its core belief: people—and society—could be **perfected**.

Faith Fuels Reform

REVIVAL

Great Awakening

Millions embrace personal faith and moral responsibility.

→

BELIEF

Perfectibility

If individuals can be saved, society can be improved.

→

ACTION

Reform Crusades

Americans launch movements to fix society's ills.

SECTION

Reforming Society

Utopian Communities



- Reformers built experimental **utopian** communities to model a perfect society.
- The **Shakers** practiced equality of the sexes and communal living.
- Most sought to reorganize life on cooperative principles.

The Temperance Movement

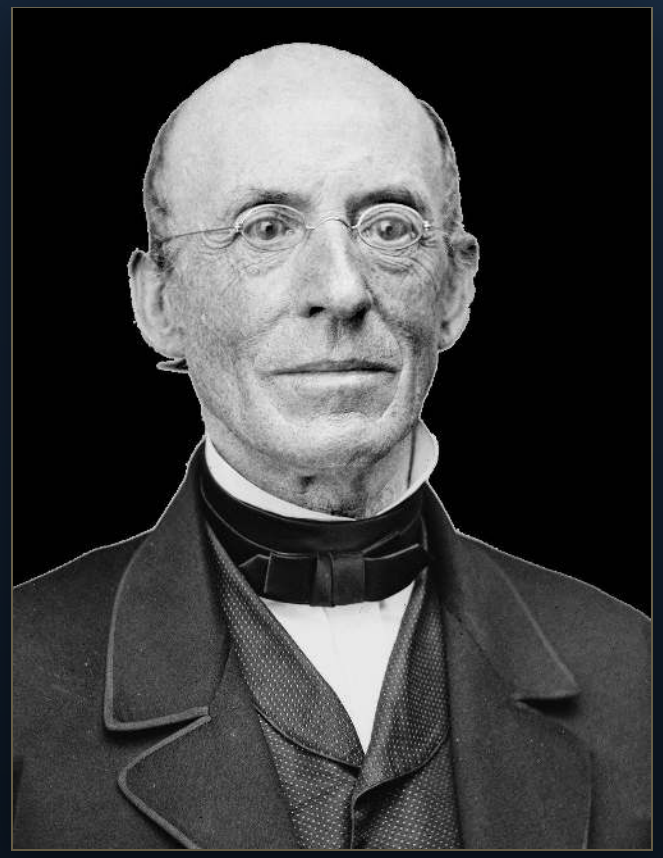
- Reformers blamed **alcohol** for poverty, crime, and broken families.
- The **American Temperance Union** (1826) grew to a million members.
- Women—often the victims of drunkenness—were central to the cause.



SECTION

The Abolitionist Movement

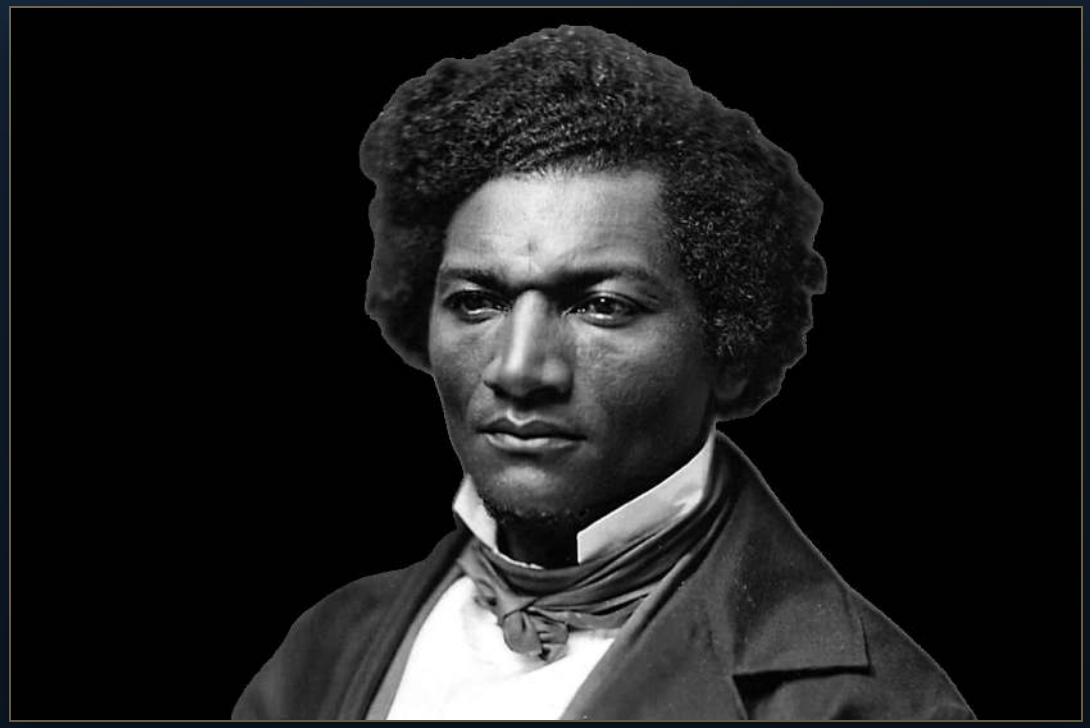
William Lloyd Garrison



- **Garrison** demanded the **immediate** end of slavery.
- In 1831 he founded his fiery newspaper, **The Liberator**.
- Abolitionists were a bold minority—often met with violent mobs.

Frederick Douglass

- **Frederick Douglass** escaped slavery to become its most powerful critic.
- His speeches and autobiography exposed slavery's brutality.
- Black abolitionists like **David Walker** also demanded freedom and equality.



SECTION

The Women's Rights Movement

From Abolition to Women's Rights

INVOLVEMENT

Women Reform

Women organize temperance and abolition campaigns.

→

EXCLUSION

Silenced

They are barred from leadership and denied a public voice.

→

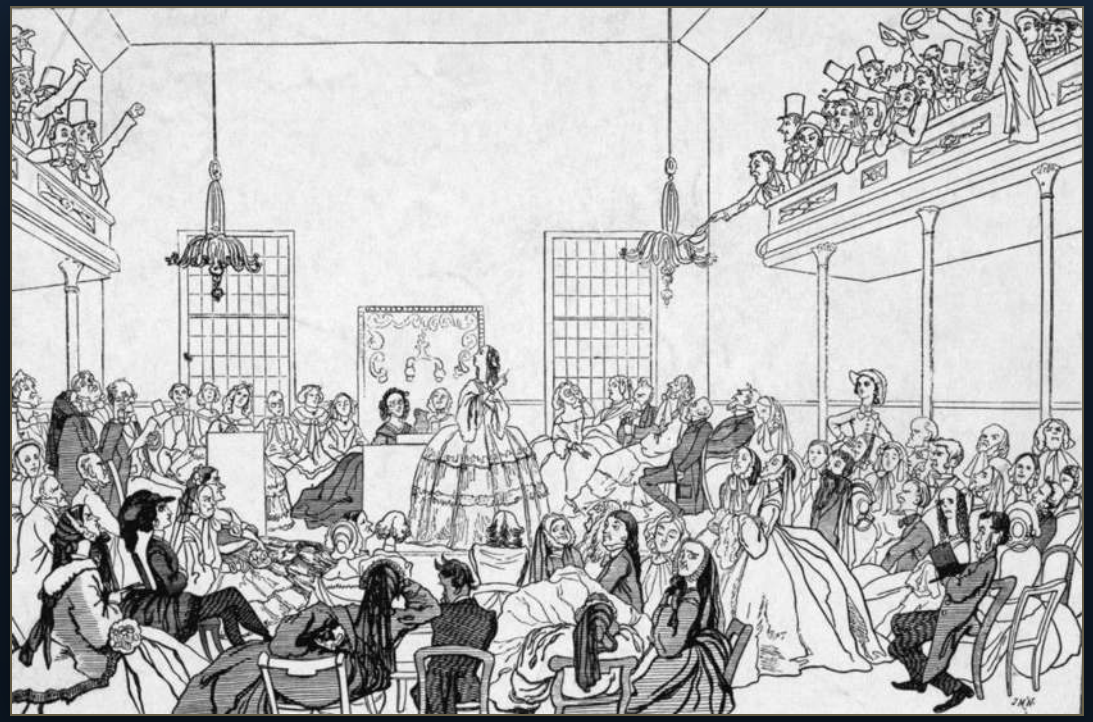
AWAKENING

Their Own Cause

They begin to demand rights for themselves.

A Historic Convention

Seneca Falls, 1848



- **Elizabeth Cady Stanton** and **Lucretia Mott** organized the first women's rights convention.
- Its **Declaration of Sentiments** declared 'all men and women are created equal.'
- It launched the long struggle for women's suffrage.

SECTION

An American Culture

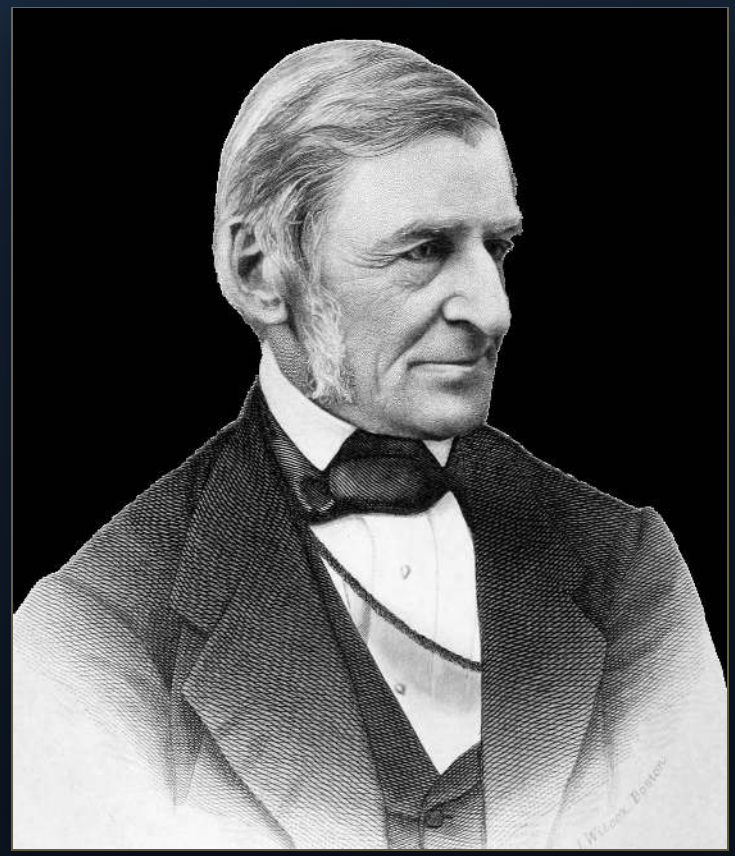
American Arts & Letters



- **Romanticism** celebrated nature, emotion, and the individual.
- The **Hudson River School** painted America's majestic wilderness.
- Writers like Cooper and Whitman forged a distinctly American voice.

Transcendentalism

- **Ralph Waldo Emerson** preached **self-reliance** and individual intuition.
- **Henry David Thoreau** found truth in nature and civil disobedience.
- They urged Americans to trust the self over convention.



KEY TAKEAWAYS

An Age of Reform

1. The **Second Great Awakening**'s belief in human **perfectibility** sparked a wave of reform.
2. **Abolitionists** (Garrison, Douglass) and **women's rights** reformers (Stanton, Mott at **Seneca Falls**) challenged the nation's deepest injustices.
3. A distinct **American culture**—**Romanticism**, the **Hudson River School**, and **Transcendentalism**—celebrated nature and the individual.

DISCUSS & APPLY

An Age of Reform

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how the **Second Great Awakening** fueled the era's reform movements.

COMPARISON

Compare the goals of the **abolitionist** and **women's rights** movements. How were they connected?

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did the ideal of **human perfectibility** reshape American ideas about society, faith, and the individual?

Up next — **Class 21: Manifest Destiny** (Texas, Oregon & westward expansion)